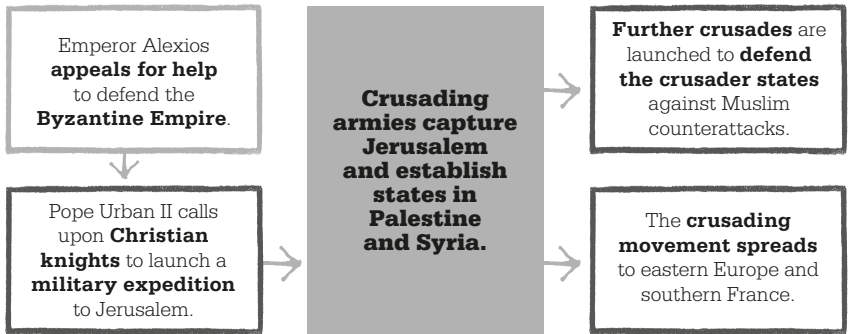




The Just War

Pope Urban readily seized a cause that would enhance papal prestige. In a sermon of 1095, he described atrocities against Christians in the Holy Land, calling for an expedition to free them. Christian warriors rallied to the cause, eager to gain both salvation and plunder by joining a so-called Just War in God's name.

Some 100,000 crusading knights, mostly French and Norman, set out in 1096. Progress to Jerusalem was slow: the crusaders suffered several setbacks at the hands of the Seljuk Turks, and the long siege of Antioch severely tested their morale, yet they pressed on and, led by the French knight Godfrey of Bouillon, at last captured the Holy City.

In the conquered area, the crusaders established four states, at Edessa, Antioch, Tripoli, and the Kingdom of Jerusalem, known collectively as Outremer. To withstand the Muslim counterattacks, the crusaders built a dense network of fortresses such as Beaufort, Margat, and Krak des Chevaliers, which dominated strategic routes into the Holy Land.

As the initial crusading impulse waned, Outremer began to suffer from a shortage of manpower. This was partly resolved by the founding of crusading orders such as the Templars and Hospitaller knights, organizations who swore monastic vows to defend the Holy Land.

Further Crusades

However, even this was not enough, and when Muslim armies captured Edessa in 1144, a Second Crusade was called. This,

and the Third Crusade mustered in response to the catastrophic loss of Jerusalem in 1187, attracted participation at an even higher level, as monarchs such as Louis VIII of France, Richard I of England, and the Holy Roman Emperor Frederick Barbarossa assumed their leadership.

By 1270 there had been eight further crusades, and the movement had extended to include attacks on Muslims in North Africa; joining the Reconquista (the Christian reconquest of Islamic emirates in Spain); launching expeditions against pagan groups in eastern Europe, and even Christian heretics, such as the Cathars in southern France. In the Middle East, however, the emergence of stronger Muslim states, such as the Mamluks in Egypt, able to mount a strong resistance to crusader pressure, rendered the later expeditions largely ineffectual.

Jerusalem fell to the Muslims for a final time in 1244. The last crusader stronghold in the Holy Land, the city of Acre, was taken by the Mamluks in 1291. ■

“A race absolutely alien to God has invaded the land of Christians, has reduced the people with sword, rapine, and flame.

Pope Urban II, 1095”